

Justice: Comparing Utilitarianism, Libertarianism, and Egalitarian Liberalism

An original lesson plan inspired by **Lucas Stanczyk's Justice (24.04J)** (MIT OpenCourseWare). Not affiliated with or endorsed by MIT OpenCourseWare or Lucas Stanczyk. Explore the original course: <https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/24-04j-justice-spring-2012/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

75 minutes

TOPICS

Ethics, Political Philosophy

“Which principle should a just society use to distribute its benefits and burdens — the greatest good for the greatest number, the protection of individual rights, or fairness to the least advantaged?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the core claims of utilitarianism, libertarianism, and Rawlsian egalitarian liberalism in their own words.
- Apply each of the three theories to a single contested policy case and predict what each would recommend.
- Construct and defend a reasoned position on which theory handles that case most persuasively, while anticipating at least one objection.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard or shared doc for recording the class's initial vote
- One printed case-study handout per student (a redistribution policy scenario — see Warm-Up)
- Sticky notes or index cards for anonymous voting
- Three labeled poster sheets, one per theory, for the small-group activity

Lesson Procedure

Warm-Up: The Anonymous Vote

10 min

Present the class with a concrete policy case, e.g.: “A state proposes a 90% tax on lottery winnings above \$10 million, using the revenue to fund free public healthcare. Should this pass?” Have students vote yes/no anonymously on an index card before any theory has been introduced, and collect a rough tally. Tell them you'll return to this same vote at the end of class.

Direct Instruction: Three Theories, Three Starting Points

20 min

Introduce the three theories with a simple comparison chart on the board (Core value / What justice requires / Most famous objection): utilitarianism (Bentham and Mill — maximize aggregate welfare), libertarianism (Nozick — justice is about how holdings were acquired, not how equal the outcome looks, and taxation for redistribution is treated as compelled labor), and egalitarian liberalism (Rawls — principles chosen behind a veil of ignorance, permitting inequality only when it benefits the least advantaged). Keep this brief — the goal is a working vocabulary for the activity that follows, not a full lecture.

Small-Group Case Analysis

25 min

Divide the class into three groups, one per theory. Each group must argue the lottery-tax case (or a second case you provide, e.g. a proposed university affirmative-action policy) strictly from their assigned theory's perspective, even if group members personally disagree with it. Groups should produce three supporting reasons and anticipate the strongest objection a rival theory would raise against them, recorded on their poster sheet.

Whole-Class Debate

15 min

Each group presents its position in 3–4 minutes. After all three have presented, open the floor for cross-examination: students from other groups may challenge a group's reasoning using their own theory's tools. Push for direct engagement — “what would the libertarian say to the utilitarian's answer?” — rather than three parallel monologues.

Closure: The Re-Vote

5 min

Have students vote anonymously again on the original lottery-tax case. Reveal both tallies. Ask for a show of hands: who changed their vote, and because of which theory's argument? Close by naming that shifting one's view under good argument is not a failure of conviction — it's the whole point of moral reasoning.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does utilitarianism give up too much when it comes to protecting individual rights, if violating one person's rights would make everyone else sufficiently happier?
- 2 Is Nozick right that taxation for redistribution is relevantly similar to forced labor? What disanalogies might block that comparison?
- 3 Does Rawls's veil of ignorance really produce impartial principles, or does the device quietly build in assumptions (like risk-aversion) that favor his own conclusions?
- 4 Can a society really combine pieces of all three theories, or are their starting points too fundamentally incompatible?
- 5 Which theory would most change a policy you already have an opinion about, if you applied it consistently?

Assessment

Students write a one-page position paper defending one of the three theories as the best guide to the lottery-tax case (or a case of your choosing), explicitly stating the strongest objection a rival theory would raise and responding to it. Grade for the quality and consistency of the argument, not for which theory the student picks.

Extension Activity

Have students find a real, current policy debate in the news (a tax proposal, a healthcare bill, a university admissions policy) and write a short analysis mapping each side's stated justification onto one of the three theories covered in class.

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